with the media. To a query on the BJP's stand on the AIADMK, he accused the media of twisting facts "contrary to what my brother Edappadi and I had actually said".

The alliance has a daunting task ahead. Electoral arithmetic, say analysts, suggests that it is a tough challenge unless they are able to get superstar Vijay's newly formed Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) on board. Indeed, the younger leadership in the AIADMK is for the party going with the TVK instead of the BJP considering the former's Dravidian leanings and, as of now, staunch opposition to the saffron party.

Vijay himself seems inclined to gauge how far his individual foray will take him. Current estimates are that the TVK may manage up to five per cent of the vote in his first assembly election—made up mostly by the youth and other members of his fan club—and that they could play spoiler for the Opposition. Vijay's reluctance to campaign till he completes a film that is still in the works could affect these numbers too.

The TVK joining the alliance also appears a difficult task as its demands will be stiff—at least a deputy CM post for the superstar and a specific number of seats. In all likelihood, the NDA will comprise the BJP, AIADMK, DMDK, PMK, Tamil Maanila Congress, Puthiya Tamizhagam and a few other small parties, with Palaniswami projected as the CM candidate. "The alliance will need a carefully balanced narrative, addressing regional concerns without compromising the BJP's broader national agenda if it is to be a winner," says B.V. Muralidhar of the department of political science, Sri Venkateswara University. The 2021 election showed the AIADMK's weakness without BJP support, and this time the party is determined to rebuild its rural base, especially among the Vanniyars and other castes who are traditionally their base.



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CURRENT ESTIMATES SUGGEST THAT SUPERSTAR VIJAY'S TVK MAY MANAGE UP TO 5 PER CENT OF THE VOTE IN HIS FIRST ASSEMBLY ELECTION

Since 2019, the BJP-AIADMK alliance had floundered after Annamalai began targeting EPS and other leaders. The BJP was ready to risk the alliance, if only to test its own strength in the Lok Sabha polls of 2024. Together in 2019, and separately five years later, the two parties have learnt that the DMK alliance is too big to defeat if they contest separately. In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, which the DMK-led alliance swept, the BJP succeeded in increasing its vote share, while the AIADMK faced the ignominy of losing its deposit in seven constituencies—a historic low for the party that has governed the state for 30 years.

For the AIADMK, especially EPS, it is a now-or-never battle. Having lost three elections in a row to the DMK, the former CM urgently needs to arrest further erosion in the party's vote and seat share. "Going by polling performances and vote share, there is little or no chance for the AIADMK to win in 2026 even in a three- or four-cornered contest," says political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy. By reuniting with the BJP, the AIADMK might be opting for short-term gains to strengthen its position though it runs the risk of ceding some of its base to the national party. For the BJP, it opens up another opportunity to grow in the state which has largely proved unreceptive to its overtures so far.

DMK chief and CM M.K. Stalin will be concerned by the alliance firming up, and is already making the right anti-BJP noises, including over delimitation, the New Education Policy, with its opposition to the Waqf Amendment Bill and by reigniting the anti-Hindi sentiment that had first catapulted the party to power back in 1967. A matter of concern will be anti-incumbency. "While the DMK's welfare programmes have bolstered its appeal among marginalised groups, the widening unemployment crisis among the youth could push voters towards other alternatives," cautions Muralidhar.

As elections in the past have proved, the stronger the alliance with identified vote-shares of individual partners, greater are the chances of electoral success. Here, analysts say the DMK holds all the cards in a multi-cornered contest with its dedicated cadre. For the AIADMK and EPS, it's a desperate battle to avoid oblivion. As for the BJP, post-election there is no doubt that it will be in a better place in Tamil Nadu, whatever the outcome. ■